

THE AUDIT · 2026

The Cincinnati Local Brand **Instagram Audit.**

18 questions most Cincinnati brands cannot answer about their own Instagram. The ones that can outperform the ones that cannot, every time.

18

SELF-SCORING ITEMS

5

STRATEGIC LAYERS

4 min

TO COMPLETE

HOW TO USE THIS

1. Open your Instagram side-by-side with this checklist.
2. Check the box if your account meets the bar. Be honest with yourself.
3. Tally your score at the bottom of each section.
4. The final page tells you what your score means and what to fix first.

01 FOUNDATION Profile & Positioning

The first three seconds. Strangers decide whether to stay or scroll based on this layer alone. If it leaks, nothing downstream matters.

☐ 01 Your bio passes the 3-second test.

A stranger reading your bio for the first time knows WHO you are, WHO you serve, and WHAT to do next within three seconds. If your bio relies on context only your existing customers have, it isn't a bio. It's an inside joke.

☐ 02 Your name field carries your category, not a sparkle.

The @handle is who you are. The name field above it (the bold one) is the most undervalued real estate on Instagram — Instagram indexes it for search. "Carl's Deli, Cincinnati Sandwich Shop" beats "Carl's Deli" alone every time. Strangers find you by category, not by branded handles they don't recognize yet.

☐ 03 Your link in bio sends to ONE current action.

Not a Linktree maze with eight options. Not a vague "shop our website." One clear, current next action tied to what you actually want this month: order catering, book a table, see this week's drop, get the guide. Choice paralysis dilutes intent. One link, one action, one outcome.

☐ 04 Highlights are organized for FIRST-time visitors, not regulars.

First three slots: "Start Here," then your offer, then your reviews. Not "Friday Funnies." A new follower decides in fifteen seconds whether to stay. Highlights are your storefront window. Not your scrapbook.

02 THE DIFFERENTIATOR

Audience Psychology

Most local brands target by demographics. Demographics tell you who. Psychology tells you why. Why is what makes content work. This is the layer almost no one runs.

☐ 05 Your dream outcome is named at three layers, not one.

Tangible (what they walk away with). Emotional (how they feel). Social (how others perceive them when they have it). "More customers" is not a dream outcome. "I want our catering operation to be the one every Cincinnati office defaults to without thinking, so I stop competing on price" is. If you cannot articulate it in three layers, you cannot write content that earns it.

☐ 06 You know the three real objections, and the fear underneath each.

Not the surface objection. The fear, doubt, or uncertainty underneath it. "Too expensive" is the surface. Underneath: "I'll get judged for spending this." "Not sure I'll use it" is the surface. Underneath: "I've been burned by something that looked great on Instagram and was average in person." Content that addresses the surface objection loses. Content that addresses the fear underneath converts.

☐ 07 You can name the dominant psychological driver behind the buy.

Status, social approval, fear of loss, certainty, identity, social proof, or simple enjoyment. Buyers don't choose your brand because they're "34-year-old professionals." They choose it because of which of those drivers your offer activates. Most local brands skip this step entirely. The ones that don't get content that actually moves people.

☐ 08 You speak differently to inside-the-house and outside-the-house audiences.

Inside-the-house = current customers who already love you. Outside-the-house = strangers who don't know you exist. Two different audiences, two different jobs. Inside-the-house content builds loyalty, drives referrals, upsells. Outside-the-house content has to make sense without context, can't use insider language, and isn't built to reward existing customers. If you only post inside-the-house, you wonder why you don't grow. If you only post outside-the-house, your existing customers feel like strangers.

03 THE ENGINE

Content Architecture

What you post and the mix of what you post decides whether the algorithm distributes you and whether the right people stick around.

☐ 09 Your last 12 posts hit a deliberate 40 / 35 / 25 mix.

40% discovery (reach new audiences — outside-the-house). 35% trust-building (depth for both audiences). 25% conversion (move toward the action — primarily inside-the-house). The mix is intentional across the rolling 12. Most local brands run 90% conversion content and wonder why nobody new finds them. The algorithm needs reach signal to distribute conversion content. You can't skip the top of the funnel.

☐ 10 Your hooks create curiosity gaps, not punchlines.

The first two seconds open a loop the viewer needs to close. "We tried all 32 and ranked them. The winner surprised us" earns the next eight seconds because the brain has to know the answer. "Here are our top 3 sandwiches!" gives the punchline away and the viewer keeps scrolling. The hook isn't where you reveal. It's where you create the need to.

☐ 11 You have 3 to 5 pillars, and every pillar maps to a customer trigger.

Pillars are not "lifestyle" or "fun." Pillars are categories your audience expects from you, each tied to a specific motivator, pain point, or FAQ from your ideal customer. "Behind the line in the kitchen" maps to the dream of insider access. "How catering actually works on event day" maps to a real FAQ from real buyers. If a pillar doesn't connect to a real customer trigger, it gets cut.

☐ 12 Every idea passes the three-question test before it gets made.

Why would someone stop scrolling? Why would they keep watching? Why would they save, share, or act? Three questions. Every idea answers all three, or it gets cut. Most local brands skip this and post whatever they thought of that morning. The discipline of cutting your own ideas before you make them is what separates an account that posts from an account that performs.

04 THE CONVERSION LAYER

Conversion & Community

Followers do not convert by accident. The path from "saw a post" to "took the action" has to be designed. The community layer is where it compounds.

☐ 13 Every conversion-intent post drives to ONE path that's actually live.

Not "DM us OR check our link OR comment OR call." One. Choice paralysis kills conversion. And whatever path you pick — DM trigger, link, phone — has to exist and work today. Pointing to a URL that 404s or a DM trigger you haven't set up is the fastest way to burn the trust you just earned.

☐ 14 You have a DM system, not DM chaos.

Saved replies for the five questions you get most. A response-time target (24 hours floor, 2 hours ideal). A rule for which DMs the owner gets pulled into. Most local brands lose qualified buyers because someone DMed at 9pm Friday and got a reply Tuesday morning. The DM is the conversion surface. It deserves a system.

☐ 15 You acknowledge every customer story-share within 24 hours.

A DM. A repost with a comment. A small gesture. The highest-ROI community move local brands miss — and it compounds. Customers who feel seen tell their friends. Customers who tag you and get crickets quietly stop. Costs zero. Pays in referrals and loyalty for years.

05

THE LEARNING LOOP

Measurement & Iteration

What you measure, you optimize. Most local brands measure the wrong things and adjust based on noise instead of signal. The fix is two metrics and one discipline.

- ☐ **16 You track saves and shares above everything else.**

Saves are intent. Shares are referral. Profile visits are buying signal. Link taps are direct conversion. Likes are dopamine. Follower count is vanity. If you can't name your top three saved posts from the last 30 days, you're measuring the wrong metrics. Saves and shares are the two signals that drive algorithmic distribution AND signal "this matters." Everything else is noise.
- ☐ **17 You can name the ONE content format outperforming on YOUR account.**

Not the format that's supposed to win. The format that actually wins for you. Owner on camera vs not. Carousel vs Reel vs single image. Talking-head vs B-roll. Most brands assume Reels beat everything. Sometimes they don't. Your account has its own truth — find it before you commit to a strategy.
- ☐ **18 You make exactly ONE deliberate adjustment per month, based on last month's data.**

Not zero (no learning loop). Not five (no signal — you can't tell what worked). One. Most local brands either change nothing and stay stuck, or change everything and learn nothing. The discipline of one deliberate change per month is the discipline that compounds. Twelve compounding changes a year beats fifty random ones every time.

ADD IT UP

Your total
score

— /
18

15 – 18

Dialed in.

You're running a real Instagram operation. The next gains compound on what's working, not on fixing what's broken. The leaks left are subtle, and usually only visible from outside. If you want a second set of eyes on the gaps you can't see from inside the business, talk to us.

10 – 14

Solid foundation, real leaks.

You're doing the visible stuff right. The leaks are in the systems: audience psychology, content mix, conversion paths, measurement. These are the items that separate "active on Instagram" from "Instagram drives the business." Most of the remaining growth lives here.

5 – 9

Most growth left on the table.

You're posting, but you're not running Instagram as a channel. The audit revealed structural gaps across audience, content, conversion, and measurement. This is where most Cincinnati local brands sit. The good news: every fix from here compounds. Pick the highest-leverage gap (usually audience psychology) and start there.

0 – 4

Rebuild needed.

Your Instagram is currently a liability, not an asset. That sounds harsh. It's also fixable in 90 days with the right system. The pattern we see most: brands that score this low are usually posting more than the ones who score higher. Volume isn't the fix. Structure is.

WANT A SECOND SET OF EYES?

Book a 20-minute audit walkthrough.

We'll run this audit on your actual Instagram account. No pitch. No slides. A screen-share where you see exactly where you score, what's leaking, and what to fix first. If we're a fit, we'll talk about it then. If not, you walk away with a clearer Instagram than you came in with.

[Book your audit walkthrough →](#)

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